

Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist_main.tex`).

The official IST journal policy confirms a **15,000-word maximum for research papers**. The current author guidance supplied with this revision additionally assigns **200 words to each figure or table** and counts references and manuscript appendices. This declaration uses a deliberately conservative implementation of that rule.

Component
Seven body sections (<code>texcount</code> sum, including section headings and caption text encountered in those files)
Structured abstract (<code>texcount</code> sum)
Remaining front matter and required declarations (title/keywords, CRediT, competing interest, data availability statement)
Main-text tables and figures (5×200)
Rendered reference list (65 entries; conservative <code>pdftotext</code> count from the first entry to the end)
Conservative IST submission equivalent

The controlling total is therefore **14,987 words**, leaving **13 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word limit. The structured abstract contains 222 prose words (227 under the `texcount` sum convention), below 300 words.

The body grew by 521 words against the previous declaration. The additions are the new Study Design subsection documenting AI-assisted research tooling, which current publisher policy requires in the Methods section; a stated matched-utilization rank-inversion result; the driver-substitution caveat on the RQ2 reversals; and explicit limits on the external-audit codebook. Two offsetting reductions were made. First, prose was condensed and one redundancy removed: the residual left open by the unsatisfied implementation-review stage is now argued once, in Threats, with cross-references elsewhere. Second, two main-text floats moved to the online supplement — the estimand table, which the body had never cited and now cites as S47, and the insert-dispersion figure, which the supplement already carried — reducing the float allowance from seven to five and removing a duplicated figure.

Every `tabular` in the body now sits inside a numbered, captioned float, so the float allowance cannot be disputed: an earlier unnumbered tier schematic was folded into prose for exactly that reason.

The remaining headroom is 13 words. Any further addition requires an offsetting cut, and this declaration must be regenerated with it.

This total is intentionally stricter than a research-content-only count. It includes all required declaration text even though such text is commonly treated as submission metadata. It also retains caption words already encountered by `texcount` and then assigns the full 200-word allowance to every rendered float, so it does not undercount captions. The paper has no manuscript appendices. The separately submitted `supplement.pdf` is online supplementary material, not an appendix embedded in the research paper.

Reproduction commands:

```
sh cd paper/ist texcount -sum -brief ../sections/introduction.tex ../sections/related_work.tex
../sections/methodology.tex ../sections/results.tex ../sections/discussion.tex ../sections/threats.tex
../sections/conclusion.tex sed -n "43,68p" ist_main.tex | texcount -sum -brief - texcount
-inc -sum ist_main.tex rg -c "\{\}\bibitem" ist_main.bbl rg -F "\{\}\@writefile{lot}"
ist_main.aux rg -F "\{\}\@writefile{lof}" ist_main.aux pdftotext ist_main.pdf - |
sed -n "/^References$/, $p" | wc -w
```

Count date: 26 July 2026. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.